

Chicago Tribune



QUESTIONS? CALL 1-800-TRIBUNE

MONDAY, DECEMBER 22, 2025

BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

A steady stream of 'ghost guns'

CPD continues to recover the weapons despite legislation meant to curb them

By Sam Charles
Chicago Tribune

Police arrived at the three-flat apartment in the city's East Side neighborhood at 7 a.m. one day last summer.

Walking up from the basement, a young man met the team of Chicago Police Department and Illinois Department of Corrections officers in the building's common area. It was time to conduct a parole check.

Two months earlier, he had pleaded guilty to aggravated unlawful use of a weapon, and was sentenced to six months of mandatory supervised release. Just the day before, on his 20th birthday, he had been shot in the shoulder.

Officers soon found several pistol and rifle magazines hidden in a dresser, an AR rifle buttstock, more loose rounds of ammunition under his mattress, and a few grams of crack cocaine. Also recovered were four 3D-printed lower receivers — the component of a gun containing the hammer and trigger that also holds the magazine.

"Upon furthering our investigation with the ATF, special agents related the 4 recovered 3D printed lower receivers classify as firearms," a CPD officer wrote in the man's arrest report before he was charged.

But despite the seemingly exotic nature of the discovery, the case is far from an outlier. Through mid-November, records show, CPD officers in 2025 have recovered nearly 400 "ghost guns" — effectively untraceable weapons, often sold on the Internet as part of kits, that can easily end up in the hands of criminals.

Turn to Guns, Page 2



Associate Pastor Joseph L. Morrow, center, of Fourth Presbyterian Church, prays as he stands with other Chicago-area pastors in the lobby of the Cook County Building on Dec. 15 to press for action to reverse increases in home property taxes. EILEEN T. MESLAR/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Cook County besieged by property tax troubles

Problems with a system upgrade have stalled tax payments to school districts, triggering heavy losses, as community leaders demand action on bill increases

By A.D. Quig
Chicago Tribune

The due date for property tax bills has come and gone, but Cook County officials remain under siege.

On one side, a group of pastors are pressing the assessor, members of the Board of Review and the treasurer to unwind this year's bills for South and West sides

and cap future bill increases. On the other side, suburban school districts are begging to receive their share of property tax revenues to make payroll.

Caught in the middle are leaders — most of whom face reelection in less than 90 days — with only limited capacity to address their claims.

Property owners have been paying their tax bills since

mid-November, but none of those dollars have yet made their way to taxing bodies such as schools, libraries and park districts.

County commissioners have been inundated with messages from suburban school district leaders whose budgets often rely heavily on property tax revenue asking when they can expect to receive their cut.

Meanwhile, costs are racking up for the public agencies that count on the money.

As the waiting game plays out, school districts have "thrown away and wasted" millions of dollars to make do, Ben Collins, superintendent of Park Ridge-Niles School District 64, testified

at the County Board on Wednesday. Several have borrowed money through tax anticipation notes or warrants, tapped reserves or investment accounts, or moved cash around to cover operating costs.

On Thursday, Diana McCluskey, the chief school business official at Palatine School District 15, testified that her district borrowed \$25 million. Interest, attorney and banking fees will cost them about \$450,000, and lost interest from cashing out investments will cost another \$700,000, she estimated.

Commissioners haven't been able to answer when the dollars

Turn to Taxes, Page 7

Saddened by attack, fearful of what's next

Afghans in Chicago express sorrow over Guard shooting, worry about deportation

By Laura Turbay
Chicago Tribune

Beheshta was preparing for finals at Oakton College, where she is studying to become an echocardiographer, when she got a text from her sister in Italy.

"Hey, do you know what happened in the United States? They're saying they will send all the people from Afghanistan back," Beheshta, 30, recalled, paraphrasing the message.

Beheshta, who came to the U.S. in 2021 from her home in Panjshir, Afghanistan, and now lives in Skokie with her husband and young child, said she was "shocked" when she heard the news about the two National Guard members who were shot — one killed — in Washington, D.C., on Nov. 26.

"No one in this world can understand the depth of their ... sorrows as much as our people do," she told Tribune. Every Afghan family living in the U.S. has



Wakil Pasakohy greets his 3-year-old daughter, Hora, while organizing Yalda, a Persian festival celebrating the winter solstice, at the Feldman Recreation Center in Niles on Friday. JOHN J. KIM/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

lost a loved one to violence in the past, she said.

On Friday night, about 250 Afghans and others in the community gathered in Niles at a celebration of the Persian tradition of Yalda, an Iranian winter solstice festival that signifies rebirth. There they honored Spc. Sarah Beckstrom, 20, who was killed, and Staff Sgt. Andrew Wolfe, 24, who was critically wounded in the Washington attack.

Federal authorities have charged the suspected shooter, Rahmanullah Lakanwal, with

first-degree murder. Lakanwal, who came to the U.S. from Afghanistan under Operation Allies Welcome in 2021, reportedly had been unraveling for years leading up to the shooting.

Wakil Pasakohy, an Iranian Afghan who helped organize the Yalda event, said it felt like his duty to remain by the victim families' side, because he has lost family to violent attacks, too. When Pasakohy first learned about the attack, he was overcome with shame.

Turn to Afghans, Page 6

Epstein files' slow release defended

Deputy AG Blanche says DOJ's pace is protecting victims

By Aamer Madhani and
Adriana Gomez Licon
Associated Press

WEST PALM BEACH, Fla. — Deputy Attorney General Todd Blanche on Sunday defended the Justice Department's decision to release just a fraction of the Jeffrey Epstein files by the congressionally mandated deadline as necessary to protect survivors of sexual abuse by the disgraced financier.

Blanche pledged that the Trump administration eventually would meet its obligation required by law. But he stressed that the department was obligated to act with caution as it



Deputy AG Todd Blanche speaks at an Oct. 15 event with President Donald Trump at the White House. JOHN MCDONNELL/AP

goes about making public thousands of documents that can include sensitive information.

Friday's partial release of the Epstein files has led to a new crush of criticism from Democrats who have accused the Republican administration of

Turn to Epstein, Page 4

INSIDE

Israel OKs 19 new settlements

The nation's Cabinet approved a proposal for settlements in the occupied West Bank as it pushes ahead with a construction binge in the territory. **Nation & World**

Bears clinch spot in the playoffs

The Bears will go to the playoffs for the first time since 2020 after the Lions' loss to the Steelers on Sunday. The Bears defeated the Packers 22-16 on Saturday. **Chicago Sports**

